A FIELD GUIDE

The Humble Bok Choy.

Stems like river stones, leaves like jade. A little book on caring for an old green.



A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

For about 1,500 years, cooks across China have grown this plant in cool, wet fields. It asks for very little: cold water, a hot pan, and a minute or two of your attention. Treat it well and it gives you crunch, sweetness, and a lot of green goodness. Let's get a stew going, baby.



SECTION I · MEET BOK CHOY

The Family

- **Regular bok choy:** big, with thick white stems and dark green leaves. Mild, juicy, and crunchy. Good for stir-fries and soups.
- **Baby bok choy:** a small, young version of the same plant. Tender and sweet. Halve it and cook it whole.
- **Shanghai bok choy:** pale green spoon-shaped stems and a softer, more buttery bite. Often sold small. This is what most Thai shops label ฮ่องเต้.



Names at the Thai Market

- **กวางตุ้งฮ่องเต้** (kwang-tung hong-tae) / **ฮ่องเต้** / **ฮ่องเต้น้อย** ("little hong-tae"): Shanghai or baby bok choy, the green-stemmed spoon kind.
- **ผักกวางตุ้ง** (phak kwang-tung): be careful. In Thai shops this word often means **choy sum**, a leafier relative with thin stems and sometimes yellow flowers, and not always bok choy. It cooks the same way, but faster.
- **ผักกาดฮ่องเต้**: a name some shops use for white-stemmed bok choy.
- Rule of thumb: thick, spoon-shaped stems in a tight head mean bok choy. Thin stems and loose leaves mean choy sum.

(Names checked against Makro and Lotus's product listings. Thai labels vary from shop to shop, so trust your eyes.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AT THE MARKET

Reading the Signs

- Leaves should be firm and deep green, with no yellowing, holes, or slime.
- Stems should be crisp and snap cleanly. Bendy or rubbery stems are old.
- Look at the cut base. It should be pale and fresh, not brown or dried out.
- Smaller heads are sweeter and more tender. Larger ones give you more crunch for soups.
- Pick heads that feel heavy for their size, which means they're full of water and fresh.



SECTION III · WASHING AND STORAGE

The Cold-Water Ritual

Grit hides at the base, between the stems. Halve or separate the heads, then soak them in a bowl of cold water. **Up to 30 minutes** loosens the grit and wakes up the leaves. Much longer and they get waterlogged and lose some vitamin C. Swish, lift them out (don't pour, or the grit lands back on top), and shake.



Keeping It Alive

1. **Wash only right before you cook.** Wet greens go slimy.
2. If they're already wet, shake them hard or use a salad spinner.
3. Wrap them loosely in a **dry paper towel**, the same trick you use for broccoli.
4. Put them in a **loose, not sealed, bag in the crisper drawer**.
5. Swap the towel if it gets soggy.

Stored this way they last **about 4–6 days** instead of 2–3.



SECTION IV · CHOPPING STYLES

The One Rule

Stems cook longer than leaves. Whatever cut you use, **stems go in first, leaves last.**



Six Cuts

- **Halves (baby):** Split the head through the base so it holds together. Use for steaming, the wok, and sous vide.
- **Quarters:** For medium heads. Use for the air fryer, the grill, and drop-in stews.
- **Separated leaves:** Snap the stalks off the base one by one. Use for blanching, noodle soup, and the best wash.
- **Stems on the bias, leaves ribboned:** Slice the stems at an angle about 1 cm thick and roll the leaves into wide strips. The classic stir-fry cut: stems go in first, leaves 1 minute later.
- **Fine shred:** Very thin across the whole head. Use for soups, congee, and raw slaw. Cooks in seconds.
- **Whole (tiny heads):** Leave them intact for steaming and presentation.



SECTION V · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	Cut	Time
Wok with garlic	Halves or bias cut	Garlic 20 sec, then covered 1–2 min
Steaming	Halves or whole	3–5 min over boiling water
Blanching	Leaves or halves	30–60 sec (baby) to 2 min, then ice water
Instant Pot stew drop-in	Quarters or leaves	After pressure cooking: stir in, lid on, 2–3 min
Air-fried crispy	Quarters, dried well	375°F / 190°C for 6–8 min, shake once
Sous vide	Halves, single layer, with fat and salt	183–185°F / 84–85°C for about 10–15 min (baby) *(estimate, based on common vegetable sous vide practice)*
Grilled	Halves, oiled	Medium-high, 2–3 min per side
Raw slaw	Fine shred	No heat, just dress and eat



Method Notes

- **Wok:** Get the wok very hot. A dry pan keeps it crisp, while wet greens steam and go limp.
- **Instant Pot:** Never pressure cook bok choy itself. It turns to mush. Add it after the pressure is released.
- **Air fryer:** Dry it really well, use a light coat of oil, and don't crowd the basket. The leaves crisp up like seaweed snacks.
- **Sous vide:** The color stays bright green and nothing leaches into water. Finish with a quick sear if you like.
- **Grill:** Char the cut side, then a squeeze of lime.
- **Raw:** Baby bok choy is sweet enough to eat raw.



SECTION VI · RECIPES (SHORT FORM)

No exact amounts. Season to taste.

Garlic Bok Choy in the Wok

Heat oil until very hot. Add lots of sliced garlic for about 20 seconds. Add halved baby bok choy, a splash of water, and a little fish sauce. Cover for 1–2 minutes. Finish with sesame oil.



Ginger Chicken and Bok Choy Stew (Instant Pot)

Sauté ginger and garlic, then brown chicken thighs. Add stock and pressure cook on high for 8 minutes. Release, stir in the bok choy, and lid on for 2 minutes. Season with fish sauce and white pepper. Serve with rice. *(From the old Carl's cookbook.)*



Crispy Air-Fried Bok Choy

Quarter and dry well. Toss with oil, salt, and garlic powder. Air fry at **375°F / 190°C for 6–8 minutes**, shaking once. Finish with lime and chili flakes.



Leftover Stew Rescue

Bring one portion of stew to a simmer. Drop in the bok choy, stems first, and cover for 2–3 minutes until just tender. Heat only what you'll eat so the rest stays crisp for next time. Fresh green life in an old pot, baby.



The Soup Drop

Almost any hot soup or stew loves bok choy. Bring it to a simmer, add the stems first, then the leaves, and cover for 2 to 3 minutes. Heat only the portion you're eating so the rest stays crisp. Best matches:

- Thai clear soup (gaeng jued) with pork or chicken
- Chicken noodle soup or khao soi
- Ginger chicken stew
- Bone broth with an egg
- Wonton or dumpling soup
- Tom yum (add it at the end)
- Beef stew or kuay teow nuea



"Oyster-Sauce Style" Bok Choy

Blanch the halves for about 1 minute and plate. In a hot pan, sizzle garlic, then add oyster sauce, a splash of water, and a pinch of sugar. Pour over the greens.



Bok Choy Noodle Soup

Heat your stock with ginger slices. Cook rice noodles separately. Add a shredded or leaf-separated bok choy to the stock for 1 minute, and add sliced chicken, meatballs, or a soft egg. Season with fish sauce, white pepper, and fried garlic.



Thai Stir-Fry with Chili and Garlic (ผัดกวางตุ้งไฟแดง style)

Pound garlic and bird's-eye chili. Get the wok very hot and fry it for a few seconds. Add the bias-cut stems, then the leaves. Add fish sauce, a pinch of sugar, and a splash of water. Toss hard for 1–2 minutes.



Sesame-Lime Raw Slaw

Finely shred baby bok choy and carrot. Dress with lime, fish sauce, a little sugar, sesame oil, and toasted sesame seeds. Eat within the hour while it's crunchy.



Sous Vide Bok Choy with Butter

Bag the halves in a single layer with butter, salt, and a little garlic. Cook at **183–185°F / 84–85°C for about 10–15 minutes** (an estimate, so check tenderness). Sear the cut side in a hot pan for about 30 seconds.



SECTION VII · PAIRINGS

Good Companions

- **Proteins:** chicken thighs, beef, pork belly, salmon and mackerel (an omega-3 boost), shrimp, eggs, freezer meatballs.
- **Aromatics:** garlic, ginger, shallot, scallion, bird's-eye chili, white pepper, lemongrass.
- **Sauces:** fish sauce, sesame oil, lime, chili oil, oyster sauce.
- **Starches:** jasmine rice, rice noodles, egg noodles, congee, potatoes.



SECTION VIII · NUTRITION

Per 100g, Raw (USDA FoodData Central, "Cabbage, chinese (pak-choi), raw", FDC 170390)

Nutrient	Per 100g
Energy	13 kcal
Carbohydrates	2.2 g
Fiber	1.0 g
Sugars	1.2 g
Protein	1.5 g
Vitamin A (RAE)	223 µg (~25% DV)
Vitamin C	45 mg (~50% DV)
Vitamin K	45.5 µg (~38% DV)
Calcium	105 mg (~8% DV)
Potassium	252 mg (~5% DV)
Folate	66 µg (~17% DV)

A 300g serving gives about 40 kcal, more than a day's vitamin C, and most of your vitamin A and K.



The Honest Note

Bok choy is a great vegetable, not a miracle. Strong evidence: it's very low in calories and high in vitamins C, A, and K, with folate and calcium your body absorbs well. Weaker evidence: claims that cruciferous vegetables (and their glucosinolates) protect against cancer come mostly from observational studies, which are promising but not proof. Cooking lowers the vitamin C. Quick methods like the wok, steaming, and sous vide keep more of it than boiling. If you ever take blood thinners such as warfarin, keep your vitamin K intake steady. It's the habit that counts, baby, not any single meal.



SECTION IX · THAI PRICES

What It Costs

*Your ledger has no bok choy purchases yet. The closest leafy green on record is kale from Lazada: ฿198.5–356.9/kg (ledger, 2024). All bok choy prices below are **web estimates** from online shops, checked Oct 10, 2026. Prices change.*

Store	Item	Price	Per kg	Source
Makro	ผักกวางตุ้งไต้หวัน 500g	฿49 (฿43 each if you buy 2+)	~฿98	web estimate, makro.pro
Makro	กวางตุ้งฮ่องเต้ organic 300g	฿59	~฿197	web estimate, makro.pro
Makro	Royal Project เบบี้ฮ่องเต้ (pack)	฿25	weight not listed	web estimate, makro.pro
Lotus's	กวางตุ้ง 300g	฿35	~฿117	web estimate, lotuss.com
Lotus's	ฮ่องเต้น้อย 150g	฿35	~฿233	web estimate, lotuss.com
Big C	ผักกวางตุ้ง	~฿65/kg	~฿65	web estimate, search summary only (unverified)
Tops	ฮ่องเต้น้อย 200g	~฿45	~฿225	web estimate, search summary only (unverified)

Rule of thumb: Choy sum-style กวางตุ้ง costs about ฿65–120/kg, and baby or Shanghai ฮ่องเต้ about ฿200–235/kg. A 300g side dish costs roughly ฿20–70. Once your Freshket and market purchases reach the ledger, these will switch to your real prices.



Closing

Cold water, a hot pan, and a little patience. The old ones knew it, and now you do too. Go get a stew going, baby.

Sources

- USDA FoodData Central, FDC 170390 "Cabbage, chinese (pak-choi), raw" (via nutri-db.com/en/foods/170390 and micronutritious.com mirrors of USDA data).
- Makro PRO: makro.pro/th/p/826833-7078708707523, /160495-7275660476611, /859346-748719031802652
- Lotus's: lotuss.com/th/product/e-14757826, /e-50792483
- Big C and Tops: from a web search summary only, with no product page verified.
- Ledger: Julius's own price records (no bok choy; kale used as a reference only).